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This Month in Geopolitics

November 2026: Key events, themes and trends to watch in the month ahead

30 October 2026

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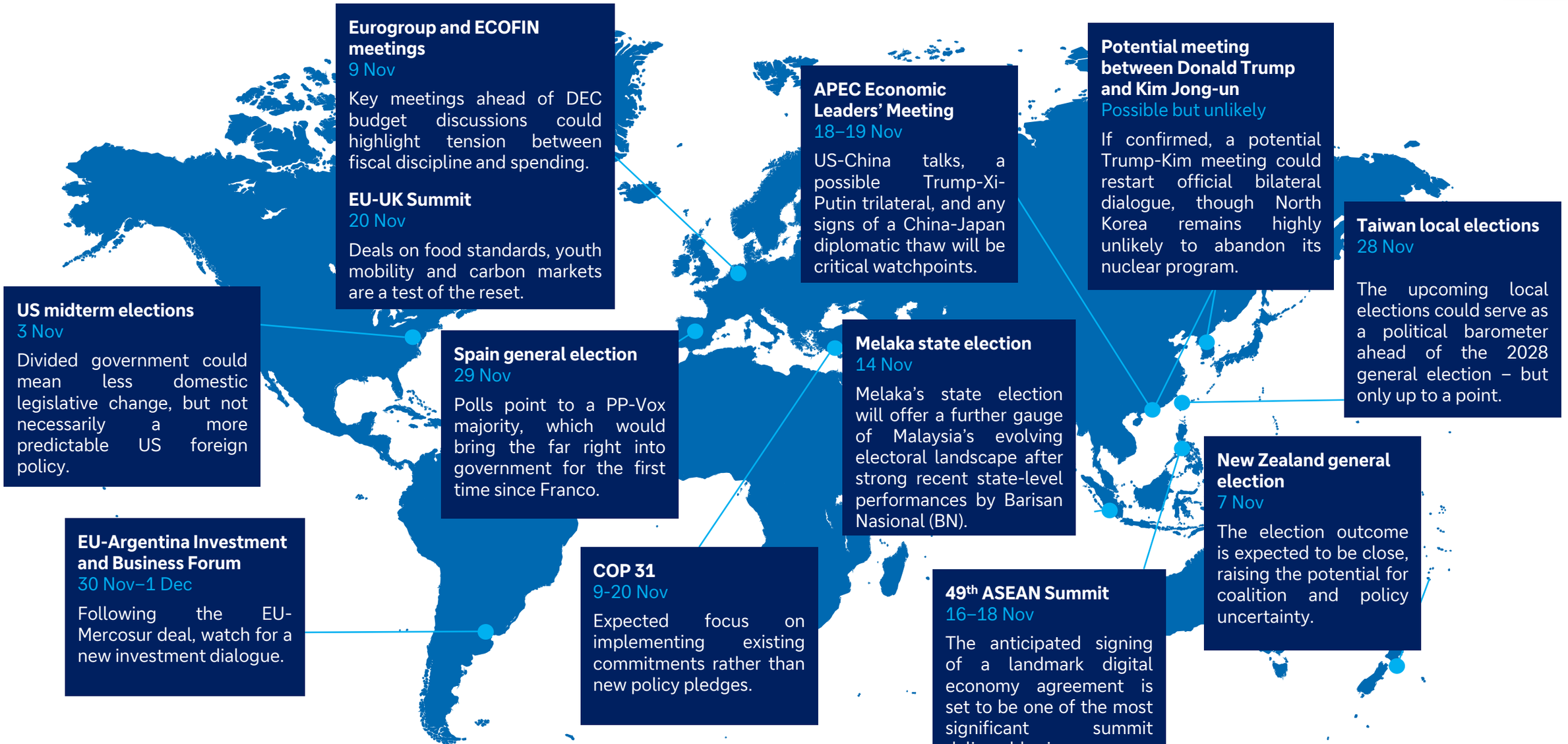
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IMPORTANT RESEARCH DISCLOSURES LOCATED IN APPENDIX 1.

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At a Glance: Geopolitical events to watch in **November 2026**

This Month in Geopolitics highlights key events, issues, and themes for the month ahead. The map below provides an at-a-glance summary, with detailed analysis provided in the subsequent slides. For a longer-term outlook (November 2026 – January 2027), please refer to our latest 90-day Geopolitical Risk Radar.



Eurogroup and ECOFIN meetings
9 Nov

Key meetings ahead of DEC budget discussions could highlight tension between fiscal discipline and spending.

EU-UK Summit
20 Nov

Deals on food standards, youth mobility and carbon markets are a test of the reset.

APEC Economic Leaders' Meeting
18–19 Nov

US-China talks, a possible Trump-Xi-Putin trilateral, and any signs of a China-Japan diplomatic thaw will be critical watchpoints.

Potential meeting between Donald Trump and Kim Jong-un
Possible but unlikely

If confirmed, a potential Trump-Kim meeting could restart official bilateral dialogue, though North Korea remains highly unlikely to abandon its nuclear program.

Taiwan local elections
28 Nov

The upcoming local elections could serve as a political barometer ahead of the 2028 general election – but only up to a point.

US midterm elections
3 Nov

Divided government could mean less domestic legislative change, but not necessarily a more predictable US foreign policy.

Spain general election
29 Nov

Polls point to a PP-Vox majority, which would bring the far right into government for the first time since Franco.

Melaka state election
14 Nov

Melaka's state election will offer a further gauge of Malaysia's evolving electoral landscape after strong recent state-level performances by Barisan Nasional (BN).

New Zealand general election
7 Nov

The election outcome is expected to be close, raising the potential for coalition and policy uncertainty.

EU-Argentina Investment and Business Forum
30 Nov–1 Dec

Following the EU-Mercosur deal, watch for a new investment dialogue.

COP 31
9-20 Nov

Expected focus on implementing existing commitments rather than new policy pledges.

49th ASEAN Summit
16–18 Nov

The anticipated signing of a landmark digital economy agreement is set to be one of the most significant summit deliverables in years.

In the spotlight for November 2026: US midterms and APEC Summit

US midterm elections (3 November)

A divided government could mean less change at home but more abroad. Third-party polling and betting markets forecast Democrat control of the House, and an increasing probability of flipping the Senate. 80% of respondents in our monthly poll now say living costs will influence their vote – the most since April. For markets, a divided government could mean less domestic legislative change, but not necessarily a more predictable US foreign policy. Losing Congress could leave the administration's geopolitical and geoeconomic toolkit largely intact.

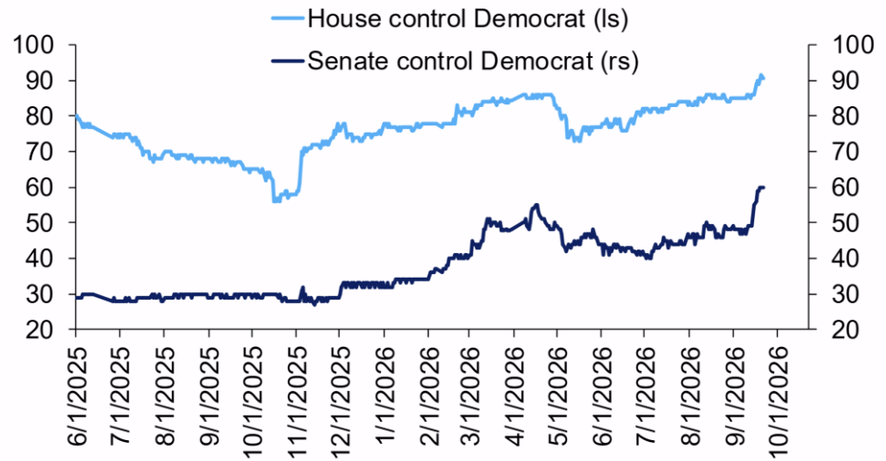
In our view, **weapons stockpiles, inflationary pressures and long-end yields may matter more than Congress in constraining the administration's choices** in 2027 and 2028. A Democratic House could dial up oversight of the administration, launch investigations, force votes on War Powers Resolutions, and use appropriations bills to press for restrictions on departmental funding. This may generate a steady stream of attention-grabbing headlines, but whether it decisively affects the event-driven risk that matters for markets (e.g. blocking a tariff or preventing a limited military strike) remains in doubt. If domestic policymaking becomes more challenging, foreign policy could become a top priority for the Trump administration.

APEC Economic Leaders' Meeting in Shenzhen (18-19 November)

US-China talks, a possible Trump-Xi-Putin trilateral meeting, and any signs of a China-Japan diplomatic thaw will be critical watchpoints. The priorities of the summit between representatives of 21 Asia-Pacific economies are set to include efforts to boost innovation, digital connectivity, supply-chain resilience and support for an open multilateral trading system. During the summit, presidents Trump and Xi are expected to meet for the third time this year. This meeting will provide signals on the state of China-US talks, including the operationalisation of new bilateral trade and investment boards, and on the likelihood of another extension of the Busan trade truce beyond January 2027. President Trump has also indicated he is open to a trilateral US-China-Russia meeting during the summit, possibly covering nuclear arms control and the Russia-Ukraine war.

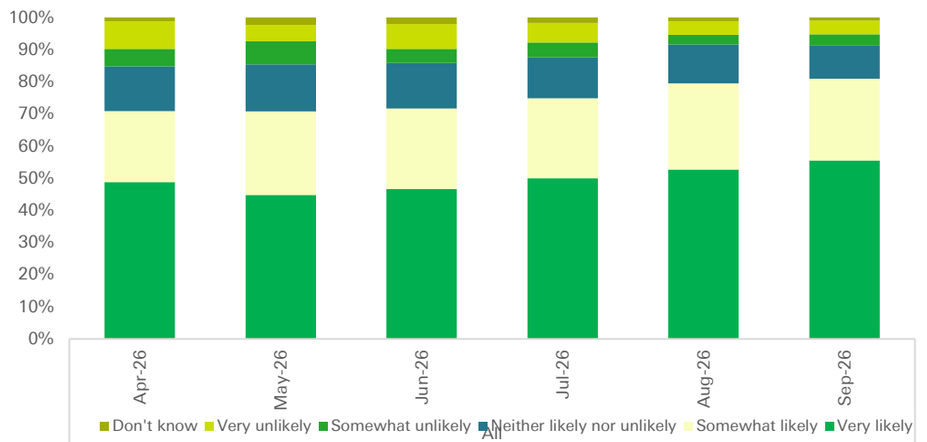
Investors will also closely watch whether Japanese Prime Minister Takaichi and President Xi meet on the sidelines, following reports that Tokyo is hoping to arrange a meeting. However, the bar for a formal breakthrough will likely remain high. As we noted in a report earlier this year, a full normalisation of relations and an easing of Chinese economic restrictions – which include rare-earth export controls – may require a lengthy period of diplomatic re-engagement and backchannel diplomacy.

Implied probability of Democrat control post 2026 mid-term election



Source: Kalshi, Bloomberg Finance LP. See: US Economic Chartbook: US midterm elections: Senate race heats up in the home stretch

US participants were asked: How likely or unlikely is it that current cost-of living concerns will influence your vote in the midterms?



Source: dbDataInsights. Responses collected April-September 2026 from an Online Nationally Representative sample of ~600 US respondents.

Key events, issues and themes to watch in November 2026

Listed in chronological order

New Zealand general election (7 November)

New Zealand's general election is shaping up as a close and fragmented contest. Both the ruling National and opposition Labour parties are polling at historically low levels, and smaller parties will likely determine the next government. In a closely contested vote, investors could see coalition uncertainty and a wider range of possible outcomes for tax, spending, infrastructure, energy and migration policy.

The National party is campaigning on a platform that would broadly preserve the current emphasis on fiscal restraint, lower regulation and private-sector investment. A Labour-led government could place greater weight on public services, housing and climate policy, alongside a proposed capital-gains tax on investment property. However, because any government will rely on minor parties for survival, the final policy mix will depend heavily on post-election negotiations.

Eurogroup and Economic and Financial Affairs Council (ECOFIN) meetings (9 November)

The meeting will be a test of the EU's ability to **translate the competitiveness agenda into practical reforms**. The focus will be on Europe's ability to restore competitiveness, mobilize investment and maintain fiscal discipline. The Eurogroup brings together Euro-area finance ministers and is expected to consider macroeconomic and fiscal developments, energy market pressures and progress towards the Savings and Investments Union. ECOFIN brings together all EU finance ministers, and will focus on financial integration, banking sector competitiveness, and economic coordination. To watch will be tensions between fiscal consolidation and the need to fund defence, energy security and strategic investment, alongside progress on integrating Europe's fragmented capital markets and banking sectors. A budget-focused Council meeting follows on 10 November.

COP 31 in Türkiye (9-20 November)

Implementation of existing commitments, rather than new policy pledges, is expected to be the primary focus of the next climate summit in Antalya. Building on the shift towards implementation at COP30, COP31 will focus on translating existing climate commitments into practical action, including through investment, financing and partnerships. For investors, the key watchpoint will be whether the summit can deliver tangible commitments that translate existing plans into binding funding pledges for critical infrastructure resilience, scaled-up renewable energy output, and climate finance.



Source: Jill Beckmann on Unsplash

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Melaka state election (14 November)

Melaka's state election will offer a further gauge of Malaysia's evolving electoral landscape after strong recent state-level performances by Barisan Nasional (BN). The contest will also be watched for its read-through to Prime Minister Anwar Ibrahim's Pakatan Harapan (PH), following setbacks in other state elections this year.

BN enters the election from a position of relative strength, while its electoral understanding with PAS and its allies could provide an early indication of how political alignments are evolving ahead of the next general election. However, Melaka's local dynamics mean the result should not be treated as a direct national forecast.

49th ASEAN Summit (16-18 November)

The anticipated signing of a landmark digital economy agreement is set to be one of the most significant summit deliverables in years. The 49th ASEAN Summit in Manila will focus on economic integration, energy security, supply-chain resilience, maritime security, the crisis in Myanmar, and relations with external partners.

For markets, the formal signing of the ASEAN Digital Economy Framework Agreement (DEFA) is the key event to watch. Designed as a legally binding treaty, DEFA aims to harmonize regional digital trade rules and cross-border data flows. Successful implementation is expected to double the projected size of the region's digital economy by 2030, boosting it from a projected baseline of US$1 trillion to US$2 trillion (up from approximately US$300 billion today).

EU-UK Summit (20 November)

The second EU-UK Summit will be an important **test of whether the post-Brexit relationship** can move towards tangible outcomes. Prime Minister Andy Burnham will seek to finalize agreements on food and agricultural standards, youth mobility, and linking emissions trading systems. Burnham has framed relations as "not good enough." To watch will be whether we see concrete deals versus declarations, and whether leaders are prepared to make the concessions necessary to deepen ties.



Source: istockphoto

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Taiwan local elections (28 November)

The upcoming local elections could serve as a political barometer ahead of the 2028 general election – but only up to a point. Local elections in Taiwan are primarily driven by municipal 'bread and butter' economic issues; geopolitics and cross-Strait relations have historically not been at the forefront of voters' concerns. While this divergence limits the elections' predictive value for the January 2028 general vote, the results can provide a sense of the domestic balance of power.

Elections in Taiwan's six special municipalities – Taipei, New Taipei, Taichung, Tainan, Taoyuan, and Kaohsiung – will serve as particularly important watchpoints. Some recent polling suggests a potentially close contest in Taipei between incumbent mayor Chiang Wan-an (Kuomintang) and legislator Shen Po-yang (Democratic Progressive Party).

Spain general election (29 November)

Spain's snap general election could mark a **major turning point for Spanish politics** and the EU, potentially ending eight years of Socialist-led government under Pedro Sánchez and bringing the conservative People's Party (PP) to power with support from the far-right Vox. Polling suggests PP is ahead and a PP-Vox alignment is the only one projected to reach a majority. A rightward shift in one of the EU's largest economies could occur just as Europe enters a wider electoral cycle, potentially complicating consensus on migration, climate policy, Ukraine and European integration.

EU-Argentina Investment and Business Forum (30 November – 1 December)

The Forum comes at a **pivotal moment in EU-Latin American relations**. It is the EU's first big commercial push into Argentina since the EU-Mercosur trade deal began to be provisionally applied on 1 May. The agreement opens new opportunities for trade, investment and market access. The EU is Argentina's largest source of foreign direct investment. Around 800 government, business and financial leaders will focus on energy, critical minerals, agriculture and infrastructure. The EU's Global Gateway investment agenda provides a framework for mobilizing public and private capital. While a key outcome will be the launch of a structured EU-Argentina investment dialogue, to watch will be the ability of Argentine officials to allay concerns around policy stability and regulatory predictability.



Source: Nestor Barbitta on Unsplash

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Potential meeting between Donald Trump and Kim Jong-un (possible but increasingly unlikely at time of writing)

A potential Trump-Kim meeting in November could restart official bilateral dialogue, though North Korea remains highly unlikely to abandon its nuclear program. South Korea's National Intelligence Service said in late September that it saw a roughly **50% chance** of US-North Korea talks around the APEC Summit in Shenzhen, although **more recent reporting suggests the prospects may have diminished**. If talks do resume, they would only mark the first step in a long and highly uncertain diplomatic process.

As we noted earlier this year, North Korea is highly unlikely to agree to denuclearization. Unless renewed negotiations sidestep denuclearization in favor of a risk-reduction or coexistence framework, dialogue is likely to stall, not least given Pyongyang's constitutional pledge to continue expanding its nuclear arsenal. This would make even a negotiated freeze on further expansion difficult to achieve.



Source: istockphoto

Appendix 1

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